Kitchen *& Kettle*

Simple Homekeeping Guide

INTERACTIVE EDITION

Cleaning recipes from kitchen ingredients, simple routines, and honest guidance. Check off tasks as you go.

Why fewer products?

Most of what a house needs for cleaning can be handled with three things: soap, an acid, and a mild abrasive. The rest is knowing when to use each one — and when a commercial product does the job better.

This isn't about avoiding "chemicals." Everything is chemicals. It's about fewer bottles under your sink, understanding what's in them, and spending less money.

The seven-ingredient cleaning pantry

White vinegar

A mild acid. Dissolves mineral deposits, cuts grease, deodorizes.

Glass, counters, bathroom, laundry rinse, coffee maker.

HONEST NOTE

Does not disinfect. Use for cleaning (removing dirt), not sanitizing. If someone is sick, use something stronger.

Baking soda

A mild abrasive and deodorizer. Scrubs without scratching.

Sinks, tubs, stovetops, oven, deodorizing, laundry booster.

HONEST NOTE

The baking soda + vinegar fizz is not what cleans — it's just the two neutralizing each other. Scrub with baking soda, rinse, then wipe with vinegar. Don't mix them at the same time.

Castile soap (liquid) or plain bar soap

A true soap from plant oils or gentle fats. Cuts through dirt and grease. Liquid castile is convenient; a plain bar like Ivory or Dove Sensitive works just as well — grate and dissolve in warm water, or rub a damp cloth on the bar.

All-purpose spray, dish soap, hand soap, floors, laundry (soft water).

HONEST NOTE

Castile can irritate some people's skin. If it bothers you, switch to a plain unscented bar (Ivory, Dove Sensitive). Cleans just as well and many find it gentler. Don't mix any soap with vinegar — they cancel out.

Citric acid

A stronger, odorless acid. Excellent descaler.

Dishwasher, washing machine, kettle, bathroom fixtures.

The seven-ingredient cleaning pantry (continued)

Salt (coarse)

Abrasive and absorbent. Good for stubborn residue.

Cast iron, cutting boards, oven spills, wine stains.

Hydrogen peroxide (3%)

Oxidizing cleaner and mild disinfectant.

Stain removal, cutting board sanitizing, grout, laundry.

HONEST NOTE

Keep in dark bottle. Don't mix with vinegar (creates irritant).

Isopropyl alcohol (70%)

Fast-evaporating solvent. Cuts grease, disinfects, leaves no residue.

Glass cleaner, electronics, sticky residue, hand sanitizer base.

Cleaning Recipes

All-Purpose Spray

Counters, tables, sinks, most hard surfaces. Daily use.

1 cup water • 1 cup white vinegar • optional: 10 drops essential oil

1. Combine in a spray bottle. Shake before each use.
2. Spray surface. Wipe with a clean cloth.

Do not use on marble, granite, or natural stone.

My notes on this recipe:

Soft Scrub (sinks, tubs, stovetops)

Baking soda • liquid soap or plain bar (castile, Ivory, or Dove) • water

1. Sprinkle baking soda onto the wet surface.
2. Add a few drops of liquid soap, or rub a damp cloth on a bar of mild soap.
3. Scrub with damp cloth. Rinse thoroughly.

My notes on this recipe:

Glass & Mirror Cleaner

½ cup isopropyl alcohol (70% or 50%) • ½ cup water

1. Combine in spray bottle. Shake gently.
2. Spray onto glass. Wipe with microfiber cloth or newspaper.

Alcohol cuts grease and evaporates fast — zero streaks. No alcohol? ¼ cup vinegar + 1 cup water + 1 tsp cornstarch works too.

My notes on this recipe:

Cleaning Recipes (cont.)

Floor Cleaner

1 gallon hot water • ¼ cup white vinegar • 2–3 drops mild liquid soap (optional)

1. Combine in bucket. Mop as usual.
2. No need to rinse — vinegar residue evaporates.

My notes on this recipe:

Oven Cleaner (non-toxic, requires elbow grease)

Baking soda • water • white vinegar (for final wipe)

1. Make a paste of baking soda and water. Spread over surfaces.
2. Let sit overnight (at least 8 hours).
3. Scrub with damp cloth. Spray vinegar on stubborn spots.

My notes on this recipe:

Products Worth Buying

Some jobs are better handled by a bottle someone else formulated. These are the two I keep under my sink.

Seventh Generation

Plant-based, dye-free, fragrance-free. Their dish soap, laundry detergent, and all-purpose spray are formulated without anything harsh — and they're septic-safe. When you don't want to make it yourself but still want a short, readable ingredient list, this is the bottle I reach for.

Bar Keepers Friend

An oxalic-acid cleanser in powder form — a mild abrasive that removes hard-water stains, rust, and tarnish without bleach. One can replaces stainless-steel cleaner, porcelain polish, and cooktop scrub. Wet the surface, shake on powder, wipe off. Septic-safe in normal household use.

> *Also worth buying: toilet bowl cleaner, laundry detergent for hard water, dishwasher detergent, and a proper disinfectant for when someone is sick. This isn't absolutism — it's knowing when DIY wins and when it doesn't.*

Cleaning Rhythms

Clear checks

> *A rhythm is not a schedule. If you miss a day, pick up where you left off.*

DAILY (5–15 MINUTES)

- [ ] Make the bed (or just straighten covers — close enough)
- [ ] Wipe kitchen counters after dinner
- [ ] Wash dishes or load dishwasher
- [ ] Quick sweep of kitchen floor (the crumb zone)
- [ ] Put away 5 things that aren't where they belong

WEEKLY (ANY DAY YOU HAVE ENERGY)

- [ ] Clean bathroom: mirror, counter, sink, toilet, shower spray
- [ ] Change towels and kitchen cloths
- [ ] Vacuum or sweep all floors
- [ ] Mop kitchen and bathroom floors
- [ ] Take out trash and recycling
- [ ] Wipe down kitchen appliances (outside)
- [ ] One load of laundry, start to finish

MONTHLY

- [ ] Clean inside microwave
- [ ] Wipe cabinet fronts and handles
- [ ] Clean washing machine (empty run with vinegar)
- [ ] Dust baseboards, light fixtures, ceiling corners
- [ ] Check and toss expired fridge items
- [ ] Wash one unusual item: shower curtain, bath mat, pillow covers

IF YOU ONLY DO ONE THING

A clean kitchen and a clean bathroom make a house feel functional. Skip everything else if you're overwhelmed.

COMPANY IN TWENTY MINUTES

Trash sweep — one bag, every room. Wipe the bathroom mirror, counter, and toilet lid. Clear the kitchen counters. Fluff the couch cushions. Light a candle. Nobody's inspecting your baseboards.

Laundry & Simple Care

LAUNDRY THAT LASTS

- **Cold water for most things.** Warm for towels and bedding.
- **Less detergent than the bottle says.** Start with half.
- **Air dry when you can.** The dryer is the hardest thing you do to your clothes.
- **Don't overwash.** Jeans, sweaters, outer layers — hang to air out between wears.

STAIN REMOVAL THAT WORKS

STAIN	WHAT TO USE	METHOD
Blood	Cold water + hydrogen peroxide	Rinse in cold water immediately. Dab peroxide. Never hot water.
Red wine	Salt, then cold water	Cover with salt to absorb. Rinse with cold water. Launder.
Grease / oil	Dish soap or baking soda	Rub a drop of dish soap into stain. Or cover with baking soda.
Coffee / tea	Cold water, vinegar if needed	Rinse immediately. Dab vinegar on stubborn spots.
Tomato / berry	Cold water, then sunlight	Rinse, rub with detergent, lay in direct sun. UV breaks down pigments.
Sweat / deodorant	White vinegar soak	Soak 30 min before washing. Prevents yellowing.

TWICE-A-YEAR RESET

> *The stuff nobody remembers until it's overdue. Pick a weekend in spring and fall — or whenever the mood strikes.*

WHEN THE WEATHER WARMS

- Wash windows inside and out
- Wash or dry-clean curtains
- Flip and rotate mattresses
- Pull out appliances — clean behind fridge and stove
- Deep clean the oven
- Wash pillows and duvets

BEFORE THE COLD SETS IN

- Clean gutters or check drainage
- Wash blankets and comforters
- Check weatherstripping around doors and windows
- Rotate pantry — use up old, restock
- Move heavy furniture — vacuum underneath
- Dust ceiling fans and light fixtures

A note on homekeeping

A clean house is not a moral achievement. A messy house is not a personal failure. These are just systems for making a space that supports your life.

If you try one thing, make the all-purpose spray. Thirty seconds to mix, costs almost nothing, replaces three bottles under your sink.

CLEANING RHYTHM THAT WORKS FOR ME

PRODUCTS I STOPPED BUYING

THINGS I STILL BUY (AND WHY)

SEASONAL CLEANING NOTES

A home that works

Cleaning isn't a moral test. A home doesn't need to be spotless to be good. What it needs is a few reliable systems, a handful of ingredients that do more than one job, and the confidence to ignore the rest of the cleaning aisle.

Works because it works.

Kitchen & Kettle

A quieter way to run a kitchen.